RENÉE BARRY

Matilda Joslyn Gage Foundation

DECONSTRUCTING THE ERIE CANAL: THREE LESSONS FOR ITS NEXT CENTURY

Abstract

In its bicentennial year, the Erie Canal is widely celebrated as a triumph of American ingenuity, economic growth, and national identity. This essay interrogates how that identity is constructed, what it obscures, and what possibilities for repair might emerge through deconstruction. Drawing on my work as the 2021–2023 Erie Canal Research Fellow, I analyze heritage tourism sites, archival materials, historical narratives, and contemporary state and museum publications to examine how the Canal is represented in public memory.

Writing as a European American settler living on unceded Onondaga land, I argue that dominant interpretations of the Erie Canal reproduce ideological structures rooted in settler colonialism, Christian dominance, patriarchy, and white supremacy. Through close readings of interpretive language and commemorative rituals—especially the Canal's 1825 opening ceremony, the "Wedding of the Waters"—I show how metaphors of birth, marriage, civilization, and progress legitimize environmental harm and erase Indigenous sovereignty. The figure of DeWitt Clinton as the Canal's "father," for example, obscures the genocidal violence against the Haudenosaunee that preceded and enabled the Canal's construction.

The essay situates the Erie Canal within a longer genealogy of Christian European thought, tracing its ideological roots to the Doctrines of Discovery and their incorporation into U.S. law. It further examines how religious imaginaries of perfection and utopia shaped social movements along the Canal corridor, including the Oneida Community, revealing how reformist projects often reproduced older hierarchies of power.

By integrating historical analysis with personal narrative, this essay emphasizes the ethical necessity of confronting complicity in systems of harm. It argues that contemporary efforts to "reimagine" the Erie Canal risk repeating historical patterns unless Indigenous leadership, ecological kinship, and erased histories are centered.

Keywords: Haudenosaunee Confederacy, unceded lands, colonization, genocide, ecosystem, industrialization, European expansion, sacred sites, Indigenous sovereignty, Christian dominance, religious revivalism, and Doctrine of Discovery.

RENÉE BARRY

Matilda Joslyn Gage Foundation

DECONSTRUCTING THE ERIE CANAL: THREE LESSONS FOR ITS NEXT CENTURY

Introduction

In the bicentennial year of its establishment, the Erie Canal remains a widely celebrated symbol of American identity. But how is this identity understood? What do representations reveal and conceal? And what would need to change in order for repair and healing to become possible? In this essay, I will deconstruct what researching the Erie Canal has taught me, so far.

My positionality in this work is complex as a European American settler living on unceded Onondaga lands. I came here to research environmental studies and better understand what role I could play in addressing the racialized systems responsible for environmental harm, ones that have privileged me and people who look like me at the cost of a balanced life on earth. But religion was a topic I wasn't ready to talk about and tried to avoid. Then I was hired as the 2021–2023 Erie Canal Research Fellow with the subject matter of its "untold stories." While studying this history, repressed awarenesses of my own life started resurfacing just like the untold stories of the Erie Canal. Deconstruction became personal as I began to recognize my entanglement in perhaps the most environmentally destructive system I could identify– that is, Christian dominance.

My job was hosted by the Erie Canal Museum and funded through a $300 million investment of the State of New York called Reimagine the Canals. First, I wanted to assess how the infrastructure was and is imagined. Otherwise, I wouldn't know which stories were left untold and why. This opportunity allowed me to travel extensively and analyze over forty sites of heritage tourism surrounding the waterway, summarized in a paper I published with my former professor in environmental studies (Barry & Teron, 2023). I spent time with archival materials, including popular historical novels, to contextualize my findings. I also started to examine present–day promotional materials as artifacts that future historians might study.

Two such future artifacts– the Reimagine the Canals Task Force Report and the Erie Canalway

National Heritage Corridor (ECNHC) brochure– introduced me to what I would find throughout New York today: a dominant narrative embodied and reinforced through interpretive signage, historical markers, museum exhibits, murals, guided tours, and, of course, the Canal itself. The 2020 Reimagine Report reflects this narrative. It describes the Erie Canal as once "a man–made ditch across hundreds of miles of wilderness," which is essentially the "story of America," a story defined by economic growth, westward expansion, settlement, progress, and civilization. The document imagines how the "industrial revolution transformed a largely unpopulated and unheralded place into a global superpower" and that new projects today can serve to "cement the State's place as a leader in the fight against the ravages of climate change."

The ECNHC brochure I used to inform which sites I would visit across New York shares a similar tone. Under the title "A Water Route to National Unity and World Trade," the pamphlet celebrates:

Americans have always been a restless lot, with an urge to move beyond their home territories. For many at the beginning of the 19th century, the Erie Canal was the route to opportunity and

prosperity in the American interior. Long before railroads, interstate highways, or jets, the Erie Canal opened the interior of a continent and shaped the future of a young nation.

The environmental and social cost of America's restlessness and urges are not reconciled by the dominant narrative but commonly ignored, nor are connections made between industrialization and climate change, let alone colonization. New York State positions itself as a savior in the so–called fight for our shared environment, rather than reflecting on its role in contributing to the present–day situation. These disconnects immediately revealed to me the need for integrating various lessons from the history of the Erie Canal, three of which I will explore in the following sections.

1. *The "Birth" of the Canal and the power to define the living*

Often, I found the Erie Canal represented as being alive and requiring protection from the threat of losing its valued relevance. My source of funding was allocated specifically for this reason– in the words of the report, "to realize a vibrant third century for this storied waterway." Although I am not sure that the Canal itself is alive, I believe that its stories have taken on a life of their own, reproducing far and wide, and now we are left with the collective work of deconstructing them.

Many sources refer to DeWitt Clinton as a central, parental figure in the project. A 1905 newspaper announces, "Everybody knows that, as Governor of the State, Clinton fathered the Erie Canal." Another column (1925) describes how "the Erie Canal was conceived by DeWit Clinton, Governor of New York. He wanted a through waterway connection between the Great Lakes and the Hudson River." An article (1922) from out in Oregon establishes Clinton as "the Father of the Erie Canal," in the same piece claiming that in his time, "there was no modern theory about democracy." This statement is simply not true.

If we are to imagine DeWitt Clinton as its father, we must acknowledge then the "grandfather" of the Erie Canal: General James Clinton of the 1779 Sullivan–Clinton genocide, which preceded and made possible the Canal's 1817–1825 construction. This family detail begins to unravel the misrepresentation that New York was an unpopulated and unheralded wilderness prior to 1817. Rather, it was and is the ancestral homelands of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy, whose democratic form of governance directly inspired American founders like Benjamin Franklin, and whose annihilation was ordered by America's "father," George Washington. Thus, there would be no Erie Canal today without this scorched earth violence, nor would there be American democracy without the Haudenosaunee Confederacy. Yet it seems more widely acceptable to present the Canal as alive and deserving of protection than to acknowledge the lives and stories of the peoples and ecosystems who were and still are harmed by the creation of this infrastructure, those whose realities contradict the popular historical narrative.

The origin story of the Erie Canal is thus more than two hundred years old. It goes further back, before even 1779, to 15th–century religious texts from the Vatican. The Doctrines of Discovery were papal bulls that historically legitimized and justified the economically motivated violence of the Age of Exploration and the transatlantic slave trade. This ideology contextualizes Christopher Columbus's "discovery" of a "New World" where there were already millions of people thriving with their own cultures and relationships to the environment. But because the peoples Columbus encountered were not Christian, they supposedly had no souls and no rights to their land or labor, thus the land and their own

bodies were objects to claim by whatever means necessary, according to the dehumanizing and expansionist logic. This marks the beginning of a pattern in which Christian European peoples delineated whose lives mattered globally, imagining humanity and other species on a God–given hierarchy from uncivilized upwards towards perfection. This imagination gets reinforced by the Erie Canal. DeWitt Clinton made his thinking clear in 1811, stating that "The Deity has placed us on a mighty continent."

Right in the midst of the Erie Canal's construction period, the US Supreme Court also introduced two things, like Lake Erie to the Hudson, when the Doctrines first became integrated into American law. Through Johnson v M'Intosh (1823), Chief Justice John Marshall set a precedent using these religious texts centuries later to claim land rights on the basis of Christian discovery. Today, they continue to be embedded in our laws, with ongoing racialized environmental impacts, even after the recent repudiation by the Vatican.

White Christian supremacy is embedded throughout the history of the Erie Canal, especially at its opening. In October of 1825, the inaugural flotilla was announced aggressively by cannon fire across unceded Haudenosaunee lands. Leading the way from Buffalo to Albany was a packet boat named the Seneca Chief, with DeWitt Clinton as passenger– the son of a man whose genocidal acts in the Revolutionary War less than fifty years prior targeted the very people mentioned by the boat's name. Behind them was Noah's Ark, invoking a biblical story of mass genocide, on which pairs of male and female animals were saved by God from his own mass destruction– or in this case, held captive for display on the floating exhibit. A witness named

William L. Stone recorded the event in his "Narrative of the Festivities Observed in Honor of The Completion of The Grand Erie Canal," where he describes living beings as things, even products, including the two Seneca boys. From his perspective, the packet boat was:

Literally stored with birds, beasts, and "creeping things." She was a small boat, fitted for the occasion, and had on board, a bear, two eagles, two fawns, with a variety of other animals, and birds, together with several fish –– not forgetting two Indian boys, in the dress of their nation –– all products of the West.

Later, Stone illustrates another religious scene of the event in which:

> "His Excellency Governor Clinton then proceeded to perform the ceremony of commingling the waters of the Lakes with the Ocean, by pouring a keg of that of Lake Erie into the Atlantic; upon which he delivered the following address: "May the God of Heavens and the Earth smile most propitiously on this work, and render it subservient to the best interests of the human race."

A brief detail describes the skin color of the crowd, hinting at who DeWitt Clinton meant by the human race, and who was celebrating and benefiting from the Canal:

The eye of beauty, too, gazed with delight upon the passing scene; for every window was thronged, and the myriads of handkerchiefs which fluttered in the air were only rivalled in whiteness by the delicate hands which suspended them.

The "Wedding" of the Waters– a union or bondage?

This opening ceremony, known as the Wedding of the Waters, is a central moment of Erie Canal history. DeWitt Clinton joined two bodies of water by a symbolic act of consummation,

followed by a prayer rendering the Canal "subservient to the best interests of the human race." I have often wondered what the implications are of such a metaphor.

DeWitt Clinton is often associated with power and force, even by its celebratory narrative. We know his own father was part of the campaign in which George Washington ordered General John Sullivan to "not by any means listen to ⟨any⟩ overture of peace before the total ruin of their settlements is effected." This mindset carries through in descriptions of DeWitt Clinton as he worked to promote the Erie Canal, all the while violating sacred treaties. In a 1960 historical novel blending fact and fiction called *The Birth of the Erie Canal*, Henry Chalmers II represents his main character as someone who needs to have their way. He writes, "Clinton early achieved ascendancy over his friends and associates by becoming belligerent in his manner whenever they showed signs of disagreeing with him," and that "His natural approach was to bend people to his will." Rhetorically, one line of dialogue summarizes the project as an act of conquest: "Can't you see what the challenge of the wilderness would mean to such a man?"

In newer interpretations, one of the shifts I hear made often is that the Canal not only spread products and peoples, but also important new ideas like women's rights. Major figures of this movement, which originated locally, expressed what marriage meant at the time. Elizabeth Cady Stanton wrote in The Women's Bible:

The Bible teaches that women brought sin and death into the world, that she precipitated the fall of the race, that she was arranged before the judgment seat of Heaven, tried, condemned, and sentenced. Marriage for her was to be a condition of bondage.

In *Woman, Church & State*, Matilda Joslyn Gage even argued that "While the inferior and secondary position of women early became an integral portion of Christianity, its fullest efforts are seen in Church teachings regarding marriage" (1893, 24). These perspectives cast a new light on the ceremony officiated by Clinton. According to the very feminist thinkers whose ideas spread along the Erie Canal, marriage was a state of subjugation, bondage, and an arrangement that rendered women "dead" in the eyes of common law. It is essential to note that while suffrage did technically start in the area, it was happening long before the Erie Canal or even European colonization. The Haudenosaunee Confederacy and their well–established matrilineal and democratic society directly inspired early women's rights advocates like Matilda Joslyn Gage to recognize that there were other ways of being in the world (See Sisters in Spirit by Sally Roesch Wagner).

"New" Religious Movements and what is associated historically with perfection

The Canal has religious origins and also religious impacts. Following its transformative changes on land and lives, so much religious revivalism spread across central and western New York that it became known as the Burned Over District. The ECNHC brochure interprets how "utopian communities and various religious movements thrived in the canal corridor."

One new religious movement called itself the Oneida Community (1848–1880), a utopian experiment which engaged in various practices, including selective breeding. This eugenics project is openly documented by the Oneida Community Journal. The group's founder, John Humphrey Noyes, believed in perfectionism (a process inseparable from belief in Christ) and had a specific goal in mind: to "Breed from the best and Breed in and in." He defined "the best" as his own bloodline and other descendants of New England pioneers from the original English Puritans.

Often represented by Canal interpretation as radical and progressive, this "free love" group clearly held hierarchical beliefs, racially, religiously, and in regards to gender, even requiring its participating women to sign a contract stating "That we do not belong to ourselves in any respect, but that we do belong first to God, and second to Mr. Noyes, as God's true representative." The Oneida Community also made and sold steel animal traps, a detail symbolic of power and control. Even these women in the supposedly more liberated Christian subcultures with alternative understandings of marriage had to deny belonging to themselves, and had to deny reality by aligning with a racialized worldview claiming that certain people have more value than others. Many of the ideas that spread along the Erie Canal, like perfection and utopia, are therefore inseparable from Christianity, patriarchy, white supremacy, and colonization, reinforcing old ideas and power dynamics just in new ways.

This ideology was reinforced legally by the Supreme Court in the same town as the Oneida

Community. In the 2005 case of *City of Sherrill v. Oneida Indian Nation of New York,* Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg asserted dominance and control via her definition of reality, describing "the distinct non–Indigenous character of central New York and its inhabitants," even citing the

The Doctrine of Discovery in her footnotes. While the intentions may differ, this action from feminist Ginsburg, who typically stood for civil rights, has a similar impact as dominant representations do across the Canalway. Spreading ideas like civilization, wilderness, and progress through Erie Canal historical interpretation also shapes the perception of New York's character.

Conclusion– the Next Erie Canal

- Going back to a first–person narrative– the importance of identifying personal stakes, responsibilities, complicities in systems of harm– embodying change
- I am the daughter of a minister, a survivor of religious abuses by a new religious movement called "The New Church" (which also reinforced old power dynamics in new packages like Reimagine the Canal)
- The New Church follows the writings of Emanuel Swedenborg, who was a Swedish scientist turned mystic, wrote extensively about marriage, rigid gender roles, and sex, despite being a bachelor his entire life
- Swedenborg influenced John Humphrey Noyes (who called the 1800s the century of Swedenborg) and even Matilda Joslyn Gage, who mentioned him in Woman Church & State. Perhaps his writings spread along the Erie Canal?
- We know his writings came here and were spread earlier by another mythological figure (like Dewitt Clinton): Johnny Appleseed. Popular narratives describe Johnny Appleseed's act of spreading apples and these Christian writings as "civilizing the frontier," just like the changes brought by the Erie Canal
- I am identifying here the repetition of old patterns even in projects that claim to be new, like the Erie Canal, like utopian societies, like the New Church, like Re–imagine the Canals. It is like we are stuck in the imagination of European men like Columbus, and there are major implications for our environment
- Indigenous peoples are leaders in environmental relationships, not the State

Micron language "next Erie Canal"

The irony is not lost on me that they are making memory chips, and the role of memory in learning from the past, like "the Matilda Effect," in which Matilda and other women (including Haudenosaunee women) are erased from history– how can we learn the lessons from aspects that have been erased? What does erasure reveal?

What environmental impacts could come of this "next Erie Canal?"

Joe Heath mentions the forever chemicals associated with the industry ● Micron chose New York for its access to fresh water

In Joe Stahlman's paper on *The doctrines of the discovery and the quiet stories of the Erie Canal*, he makes the recommendation to pivot toward new topics:

"The few examples I used to make my points are tangible, identifiable, and traceable. Imagine if I pursued forms of inquiry of the Doctrines of Discovery's impacts on topics like Indigenous spirituality, nature–as–kin worldview, or language retention as it relates to positive community–nature relationships?"

"If there are living communities affected by the canal's presence on the landscape, there is a need for reconciliation with the Erie Canal. There are unlimited research subjects to dust off for the forthcoming commemoration, which can serve as an excellent opportunity to begin understanding why we need to collectively shape our storytelling."